



# RUSSIANS

RUSSIANS ARE DESCENDED FROM THE SLAVIC PEOPLE living north of the Black Sea. Most Russians were rural peasants working for aristocratic landlords until the Communist Revolution. From 1917-1991,

EUROPE'S LARGEST ETHNIC GROUP

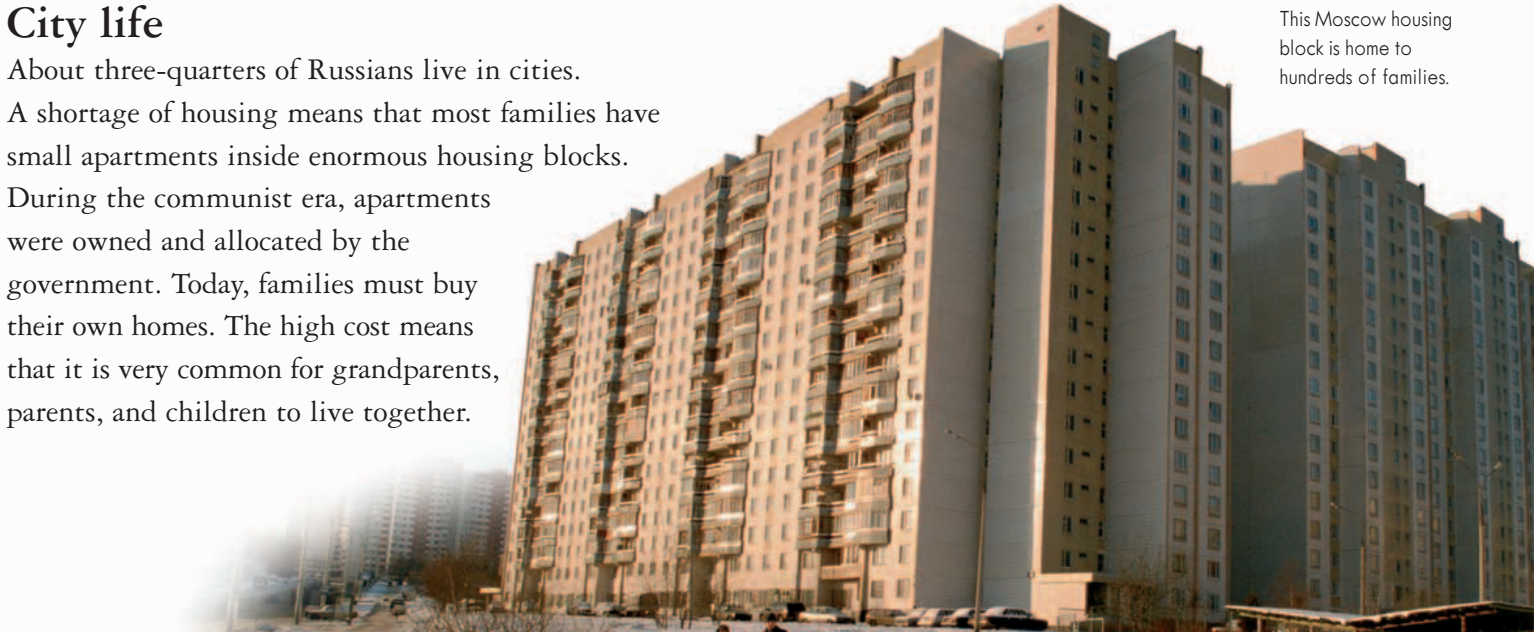
## City life

About three-quarters of Russians live in cities.

A shortage of housing means that most families have small apartments inside enormous housing blocks.

During the communist era, apartments were owned and allocated by the government. Today, families must buy their own homes. The high cost means that it is very common for grandparents, parents, and children to live together.

This Moscow housing block is home to hundreds of families.



### CONSUMER CULTURE

Until communism ended in Russia in 1991, the state looked after many aspects of peoples' lives. Food, clothing, and various other items were rationed. These days, big Russian cities boast boutiques, chic restaurants, and well-stocked department stores, but the goods are too costly for many people.



Fast-food restaurants have opened in Russia.



### TEMPERING

Russians traditionally believe that the body should be "tempered" in order to enable it to withstand diseases in the cold climate. This process, which is still performed on children today, is called *zakalivanie*. It involves briefly plunging all or part of the body into snow or freezing cold water.